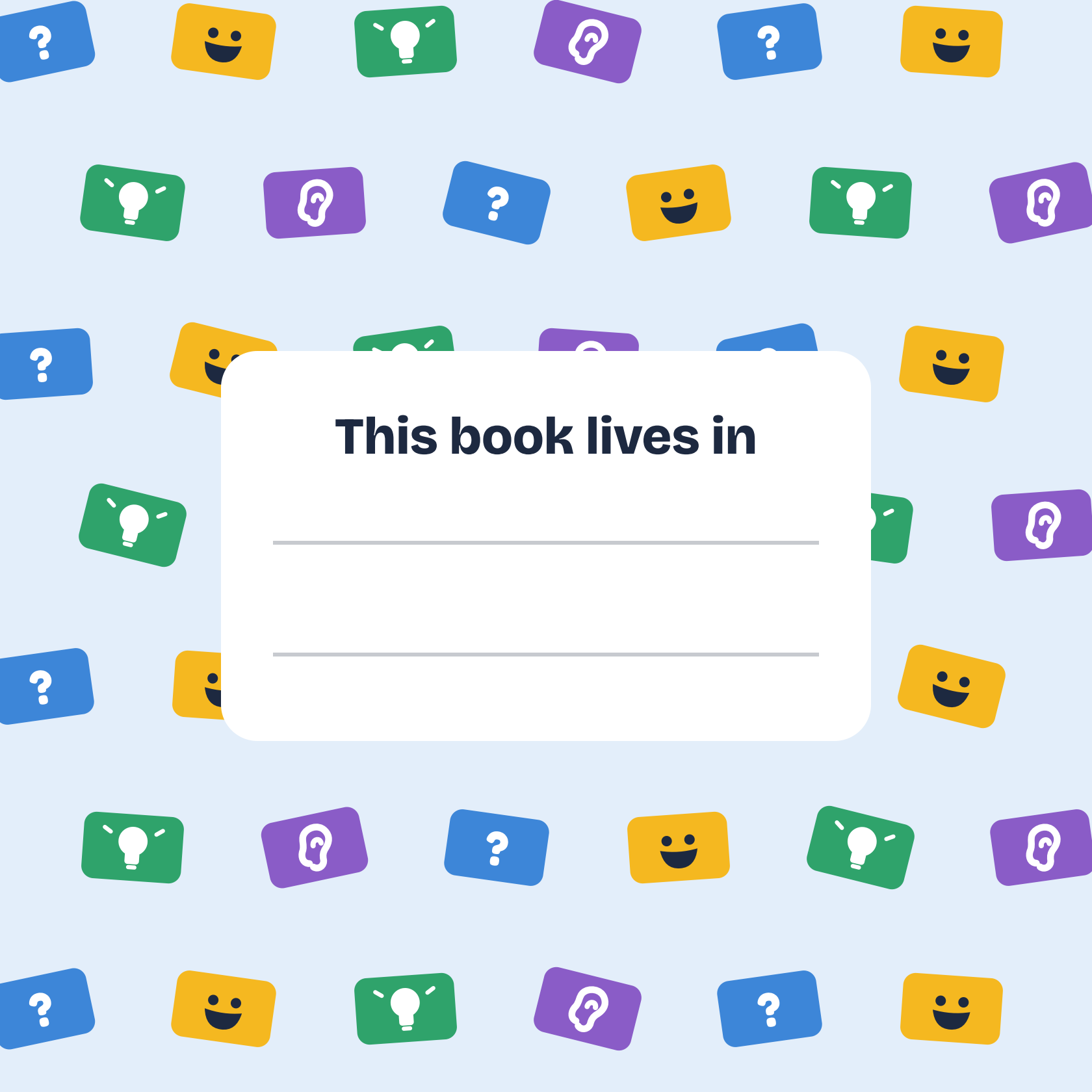


More Talk, Less Tap

**Circle-time
talk games
inside!**

A Talk Tower story for circle time





This book lives in

More Talk, Less Tap

A Talk Tower story for circle time

FOUNDER: your author line

Write it in WORDS.md, section "story-author". This box disappears once filled.



**Play Before
Pixels**



More Talk, Less Tap

Bonus read-aloud edition, included with the Talk Tower Classroom Game Kit

Text and illustrations © 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved.

This PDF is licensed with the kit: one classroom (single-classroom license) or one school site (site license). You may print it and project it for the children you teach. Please do not share, post or upload the file. Reading it aloud to your class or family is always welcome. Full terms: playbeforepixels.com/license

This is a work of fiction. Room 5, Ms. Poppy and the children are imaginary and are not based on any real school, teacher or child. The games and notes at the back are general ideas for grown-ups to enjoy with children; they are not a program, assessment or professional advice. Adults supervise all activities. With children under 3 nearby, use only blocks and objects too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm).

Published by AlphaPlay LLC, doing business as Play Before Pixels · playbeforepixels.com

Free bonus printable: playbeforepixels.com/bonus/picture-more-talk-less-tap

First edition 2026 · Version 1.0 · September 2026

ISBN / barcode

Not needed for this bonus PDF. Add one only if a print edition is ever published.

FOUNDER: your dedication

Your own words, in WORDS.md section “story-dedication”.

Meet Room 5



Priya

asks the first question



Leo

knows a joke for
everything



Zara

is full of ideas



Milo

always wants to know
more



Sam

is a great listener



Ms. Poppy

is the teacher

In Room 5, lots of things went **tap**.

Tap, tap, tap went the rain on the window.

Tap, tap went Bubbles the fish, nosing the side of his bowl.



But at circle time, nobody said a word.

Not Priya. Not Leo. Not Zara, or Milo, or Sam.

Everybody was waiting for somebody else to go first.



So Ms. Poppy tipped out a big bin of blocks.

CLATTER!



“Let’s build a **Talk Tower!**” she said. “Every time someone says something out loud, a block goes on.”



Ask a question

blue block



Tell a joke

yellow block



Share an idea

green block

Priya's hand shot up first.

Why is Bubbles
orange?



“That’s a question!” said Ms. Poppy.

A blue block went on the Talk Tower.

Talk Tower

CLACK!



Then Leo had a joke.

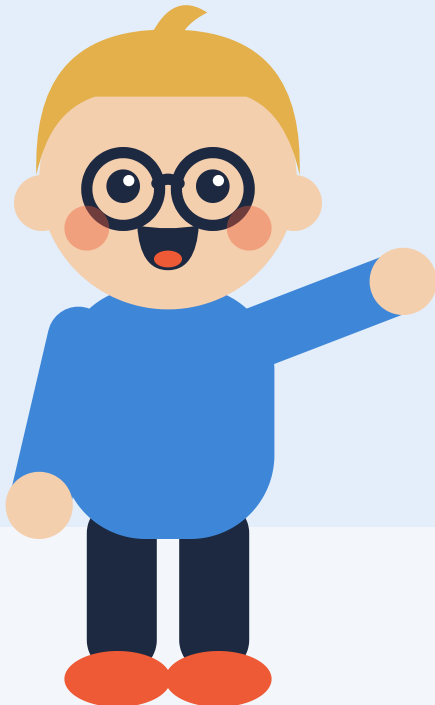
Knock, knock!

Who's there?

Cow says.

Cow says who?

No, silly! A cow says
MOO!



Room 5 laughed and laughed. Even Bubbles blew a bubble.

A yellow block went on.

CLACK!

Up it goes!



Zara watched Bubbles swim round and round, all by himself.

I have an idea! Let's draw Bubbles some friends!



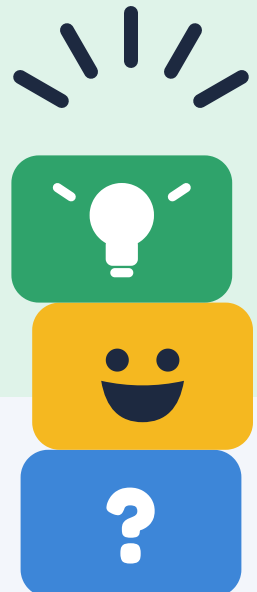


“That’s an idea!” said Ms. Poppy.

A green block went on.



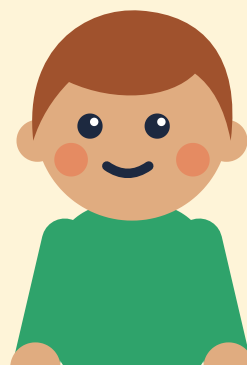
CLACK!



All week long, Room 5 talked. At snack time. At painting time. Out in the garden.

Why are bananas
bendy?

What if worms wore
tiny hats?



By Wednesday, the Talk Tower was taller than everyone. Well, everyone except Ms. Poppy.

But Sam hadn't added a block yet. Sam liked listening best.



Then, on Thursday, everybody had something to say.

ALL. AT. ONCE!

Me! Me!

Guess what—

Listen—

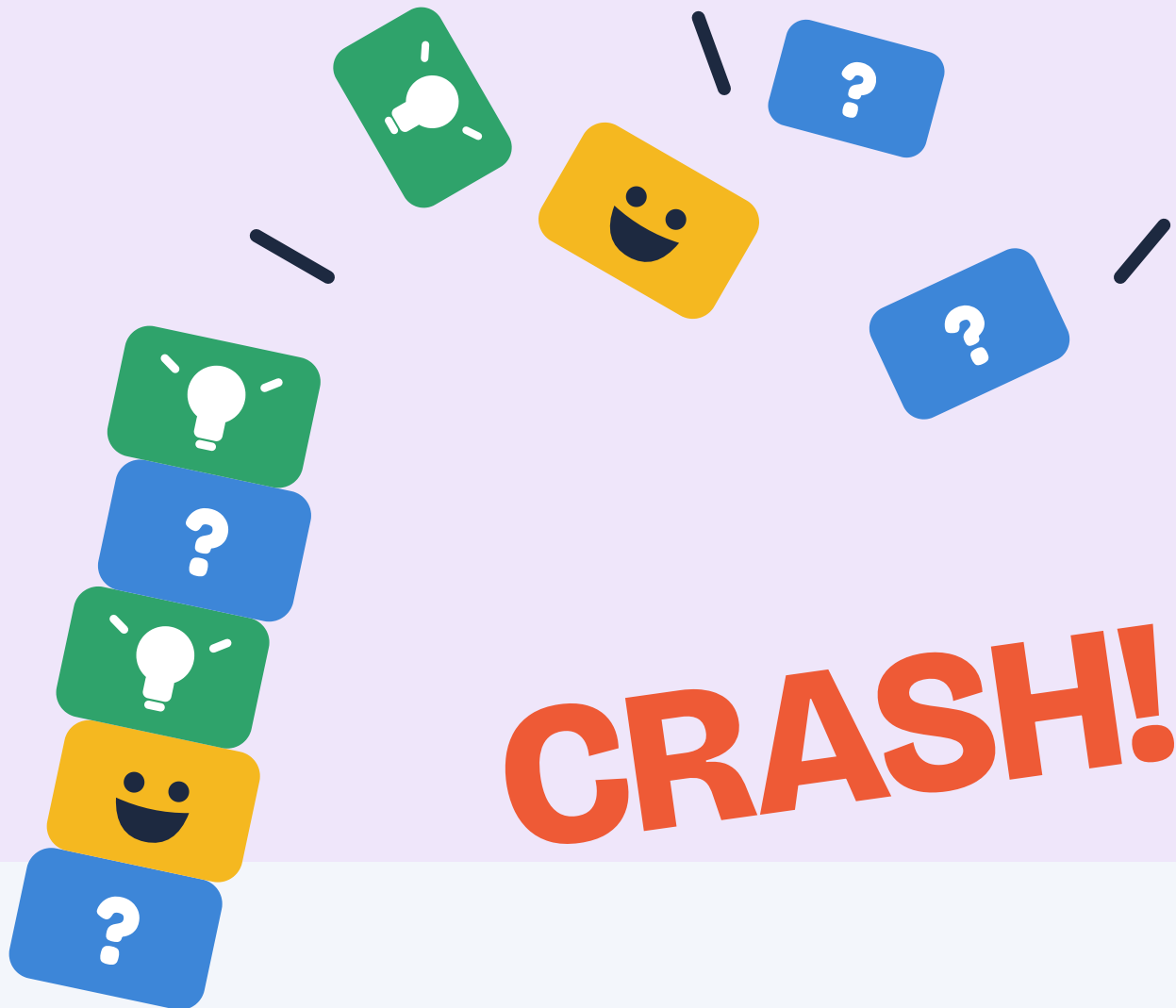
My turn!

I know!



The words got all tangled up. Nobody could hear anybody.

The Talk Tower went wobble... wobble...



Blocks everywhere. Room 5 went very, very quiet.
Then a small voice said something.

Maybe... we could take
turns?



Everyone turned to look at Sam.

Sam, that's a great
idea!

Sam's very first block started a
brand-new tower.

CLACK!



Ms. Poppy brought out the Talking Star.

“Whoever holds the star talks. Everybody else listens, with their eyes, their ears and their whole body.”



**Pass the star.
Take a turn.
Pass the star.
Take a turn.**

CLACK!

CLACK!

CLACK!



When it was Priya's turn, she talked about her grandma's garden. Milo listened to every word. Then he asked something more.

My grandma grows
giant pumpkins!

How do they get so
big?



“Milo, you were really listening,” said Ms. Poppy.
“Listening counts too!”

So the tower got a brand-new color: a purple
block, for good listening.



Up, up, up went the Talk
Tower. Past the window.
Past the clock. Ms. Poppy
had to stand on the step
stool!



“We built all that with our words!” said Priya.

“And our ears,” said Sam.

Tap, tap, tap went the rain. But nobody in Room 5 heard it. They were much too busy talking.

The End



A note for educators and families

Children get better at conversation by having lots of conversations, with grown-ups and friends who listen and talk back. Every question and answer, every joke and laugh, is a turn. *More Talk, Less Tap* makes those turns visible, and celebrates them.

Build your own Talk Tower. Big blocks, paper strips on a wall or sticky notes on a door all work. Keep it a celebration, not a scoreboard: no winners, no prizes, and nobody has to talk until they are ready.

Try these at circle time

- **Pause and wait.** After you ask a question, count to five in your head. Quieter children, like Sam, often need that moment.
- **Say what you see.** “You’re smiling! Do you have a joke?”
- **Repeat and add a little.** “A pumpkin!” “A giant orange pumpkin!”
- **Follow their lead.** Talk about what the child already cares about.
- **Count listening too.** A follow-up question such as “What happened next?” shows real listening.

Every way of talking counts: words, signs, pointing or a tap on a talking device, in the language you know best. And when the tower falls? Build it again, one turn at a time.



Talk starters for your Talk Tower



Questions

- What is the best smell in the world?
- If you were tiny, where would you go?
- What would a dog say if it could talk?



Jokes

- What do you call a sleeping dinosaur? A dino-snore!
- Why did the teddy bear skip dessert? It was stuffed!



Ideas

- Let's make up a song about lunch.
- Let's build a fort for the teddy bears.
- Let's invent a brand-new animal.



Listening

- What happened next?
- How did that feel?
- Can you tell me more?

Circle-time talk games

Three quick games for ages 3–7. A grown-up leads, everyone gets a turn, and every voice counts.



Build a Talk Tower

Whole group · 10 minutes

You need: A basket of large blocks (or paper strips and tape)

1. Sit in a circle with the basket in the middle.
2. Each time someone asks a question, tells a joke or shares an idea out loud, they add a block.
3. A good follow-up question counts too!
4. How tall can the tower grow before tidy-up time?



2

Pass the Talking Star

Whole group · 5–10 minutes

You need: Any soft toy to be your Talking Star

1. Give everyone the same starter, like “My favorite animal is...”
2. Whoever holds the star talks. Everyone else listens.
3. Pass the star to the next friend.
4. Saying “pass” is always OK.

3

Ask Me One More

Pairs · 5 minutes

You need: Nothing at all

1. One friend shares something: “I have a cat.”
2. Their partner listens, then asks one more question: “What is its name?”
3. Swap turns.
4. Grown-ups, show it first with a child.

Room 5 is building a tower out of words.

Every time someone asks a question, tells a joke or shares an idea out loud, a block goes on the Talk Tower. But what happens when everybody talks at once?

A warm, funny read-aloud about conversation, taking turns and really listening, with circle-time talk games and a note for educators and families at the back.



Ages 3–7 • Bonus read-aloud from the Talk Tower Classroom Game Kit



Scan for a free
bonus printable

ISBN / barcode
(print edition only)